Original: 4992 tokens

Iran strikes back as leaders ratchet up rhetoric

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mains at war.

President Trump had been trying to dissuade Netanyahu from attacking Iranian nuclear sites, while US and Iranian negotiators attempted to reach a deal to limit Iran's nuclear activities.

US and Iranian negotiators had been planning to meet Sunday in Oman for a sixth round of talks on a nuclear deal. But after the attack Friday, Iran announced that it would not participate in the talks Sunday.

Trump, in a social media post Friday, said Iran "must make a deal, before there is nothing left," and he warned that the next round of Israeli airstrikes would be "even more brutal."

US officials said they were moving warships and other military assets in the Middle East to help protect Israel and US troops in the region. The USS Thomas Hudner, a naval destroyer, was directed to sail to the Eastern Mediterranean, and a second destroyer may soon follow, the officials said. The Air Force will most likely move additional fighter aircraft to the region soon, an official said.

The military assets were not being positioned to take part in any offensive against Iran, a Pentagon official said. But they helped Israel shoot down Iranian missiles Friday, a US official said, just as US warships did when Iran fired a barrage against Israel in October.

Israel's strikes Friday were the first time the country had openly attacked Iran's nuclear sites, including its main nuclear enrichment facility at Natanz, which an Israeli military spokesperson said had suffered "significant damage."

Social media footage verified by The New York Times shows flames and thick black smoke billowing from Natanz, shortly after explosions were reported there at 4:18 a.m. Satellite images reviewed by the Times showed several buildings and critical energy infrastructure there either destroyed or heavily damaged.

Rafael Grossi, head of the International Atomic Energy Agency, told the UN Security Council on Friday that Israel's strike on Natanz had destroyed an aboveground enrichment plant, causing chemical and radiological contamination. Grossi said the leak was "manageable" with appropriate protection measures.

The Israeli military said it had also struck an Iranian nuclear facility in Isfahan and had destroyed uranium-enrichment infrastructure and labs. The damage could not be immediately confirmed.

Grossi said Iranian authorities had also reported strikes on Iran's second-largest and most fortified nuclear complex, known as Fordo, which is built deep underground.

Netanyahu said he had ordered his security chiefs more than a half-year ago, in November, to destroy Iran's nuclear program. The attack was originally planned for late April but was postponed for various reasons, he said, without elaborating.

"If Iran has a nuclear weapon, we simply won't exist here," he said in a videotaped statement Friday, adding that Israel was at the "12th hour."

Israel also attacked military bases and the homes of military commanders around the Iranian capital, Tehran, officials said. Iran's state media showed blasts across Tehran, with smoke and fire billowing from buildings, and residents described a night of terror, as explosions rocked the city.

"We woke up with our house shaking from the explosions, and it hasn't stopped," said Sara, a 52-year-old mother of two in Tehran, who asked to be identified by her first name only.

Iranian state media and officials said that at least four top generals had been killed, including Major General Mohammad Bagheri, chief of staff of the armed forces and the second-highest commander after Khamenei; General Hossein Salami, commander in chief of the Guard, Iran's primary military force; and General Ismail Ghaani, the Quds Force's commander in charge of the Iranian proxies in the Middle East.

Khamenei moved swiftly to replace the military leaders in an apparent bid to project stability and prevent a power vacuum.

Ali Shamkhani, an influential Iranian politician overseeing the nuclear talks with the United States, was also killed, as were two prominent nuclear scientists, Mohammad Mehdi Tehranji and Fereydoun Abbasi, according to Iranian state media and officials.

Several Israeli strikes also appeared to have targeted an underground missile base in Kermanshah, in western Iran, on Friday morning, according to witness videos verified by the Times, which showed columns of smoke rising from the site.

Israel's allies expressed growing concern about the potential for the strikes to drive more conflict in the Middle East.

"Escalation serves no one in the region," British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said, while the European Union's chief diplomat, Kaja Kallas, called the situation "dangerous." Egypt, which has a long-standing peace treaty with Israel, called the Israeli strikes "a direct threat to regional and international peace and security."

Russian President Vladimir Putin condemned the Israeli strikes and offered to serve as a mediator in the conflict, the Kremlin said, even as Russia is conducting the largest bombing campaign of Ukrainian cities since invading that country three years ago.

Israel has been facing international condemnation over the past few months for escalating the war in Gaza after a cease-fire collapsed in March, and for holding back humanitarian aid as the population in the enclave edges closer to the brink of starvation.

Still, several important allies stood behind Israel on Friday. French President Emmanuel Macron said Israel had a "right to protect itself and ensure its security." And Germany's chancellor, Friedrich Merz, said Iran had refused to abide by agreements to limit its nuclear program and added that Tehran "poses a serious threat to the entire region, especially to the state of Israel."

MAJID SAEEDI/GETTY IMAGES

People looked over the damage from Israeli strikes in Tehran.

JACK GUEZ/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

A rescue worker carried an injured girl on his back in Ramat Gan near Tel Aviv on Friday.

Iran's nuclear program remains after Israeli strikes

By David E. Sanger
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Israel badly damaged one of Iran's key nuclear sites and killed a startling array of top military and nuclear officials in the attacks that started Friday morning. But when the sun rose after that devastating assault, it was also clear how much of Iran's nuclear program remained, at least for now.

The Israeli strikes appear to have destroyed an aboveground nuclear fuel production site and electrical supply centers at Iran's largest uranium enrichment center. The killing of some of Iran's top nuclear scientists continues a long-running Israeli campaign targeting the expertise needed to build a bomb. But the first phase of the Israeli attacks did not hit the most likely repository of Iran's near-bomb-grade nuclear fuel — and that may have been deliberate.

That stockpile is stored at a vast complex outside the ancient former capital of Isfahan, according to international inspectors who are charged with measuring and monitoring it. Israel's 100 fighters and swarms of missiles and drones stayed away from Isfahan in their first wave, even though it is one of the largest nuclear sites in the country and, according to Western intelligence services, one of the centers of Iran's secret weapons research programs.

The Israeli military issued a news release Friday afternoon saying that in a second wave of attacks, it had hit Isfahan but not the fuel stockpile. Instead, it focused on laboratories that worked on converting uranium gas back into a metal.

"We saw the fuel there just recently," Rafael Mariano Grossi, the director general of the International Atomic Energy Agency, the United Nations organization that tracks fuel to make sure it is not diverted to weapons projects, said Friday. Inspectors were inside the Isfahan facilities over the past few weeks, conducting the final inventories for the quarterly report on Iran's capabilities that was distributed to the agency's board this month as it focused on Iran's compliance with inspectors' demands.

The mystery is why Israel avoided hitting the stockpile, which gives Iran its fastest pathway to producing a small nuclear arsenal. And it was the core of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's justifications early Friday for ordering the strike, after two decades in which Israel has always stopped short of pulling the trigger.

"Iran has produced enough highly enriched uranium for nine atom bombs — nine," he said.

Netanyahu went on to discuss the danger he believed the stockpile's existence posed: "In recent months, Iran has taken steps that it has never taken before, steps to weaponize this enriched uranium." He argued that if Iran was not stopped, it "could produce a nuclear weapon in a very short time."

Israeli officials did not respond to queries about why they spared the stockpile, at least for now. It is possible that the Isfahan complex could be targeted in a next wave. President Trump said Friday that "there's more to come, a lot more," adding that the next attacks would be "brutal."

But outside experts believe avoiding Isfahan was a deliberate choice.

"The fact that Israel did not bomb a known uranium production facility at Isfahan," said Jon Wolfsthal of the Federation of American Scientists, which tracks Iran's nuclear progress closely, "suggests either that Bibi was worried the bombing might cause a radiological incident or that they actually think this will lead Iran to surrender its uranium stocks voluntarily."

As US cracks down, Canada considers immigration limits

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Supreme Court decision that removes protections for immigrants from several strife-ridden nations.

Canada, and French-speaking Quebec in particular, has long been an attractive choice for members of Greater Boston's large Haitian community. And after the high court cleared the way for the Trump administration to deport them, many were considering relocating to Canada, according to Jeff Thielman, chief executive of the International Institute of New England.

The actions on either side of the border leave them and other immigrants in a quandary.

"If our country isn't going to be welcoming, which is a travesty, then maybe Canada can be welcoming. And if Canada says no to them, then what do we do?" said Thielman, whose organization serves refugees and immigrants in Massachusetts and New Hampshire. "Seriously, there's no place for them to go — and it's not fair to them."

Since taking office, Trump has sought to end a variety of programs enabling citizens of certain countries to take refuge in the US, but lower courts have slowed his efforts.

In May, the Supreme Court allowed the administration to remove Temporary Protected Status from roughly 350,000 Venezuelan immigrants while the courts continue to consider the case. That program, which allows people from specific countries in crisis to legally live and work in the US, is slated to expire for Haitians in August.

In a more recent decision, the Supreme Court let the administration move forward with ending a separate Biden-era humanitarian parole program for more than 500,000 immigrants from Cuba, Haiti, Nicaragua, and Venezuela. That program allowed citizens of those nations to fly directly to the United States and stay for two years if they had a sponsor in the country. Lower courts are still considering the case, but the high court said the Trump administration could proceed with removals in the meantime.

Canadian officials have worried since Trump's election last year that the looming termination of these programs could lead to an influx of refugees to the north. During the first Trump administration, tens of thousands of Haitian immigrants moved from the US to Canada. More than 100,000 people passed through a single makeshift border crossing from New York to Quebec between 2017 and 2023, when the two nations tightened an agreement governing the flow of asylum-seekers.

So far, evidence of a new surge in northbound migration is mixed.

Nationwide, asylum applications processed by Canada so far this year are half those of last year, 14,557 through the first five months of 2024, compared to 31,244 in the same period in 2024, according to the Canada Border Services Agency.

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>
> JEFF THIELMAN, *International Institute of New England*

But at the Saint-Bernard-de-Lacolle port of entry, which connects Interstate 87 near the New York-Vermont border with Autoroute 15 in Quebec, officials clocked a dramatic uptick in activity this spring, doubling month-over-month in March and April.

Year to date, asylum claims at that crossing — which this year account for more than one-third of such claims in Canada — are up by about 60 percent. The agency declined to provide similar figures for other ports of entry.

Rebecca Purdy, a spokesperson for the Canada Border Services Agency, said the increase in claims at that location has not affected the crossing's operations.

The most common countries of origin of those claiming asylum at ports of entry this year are Haiti, Venezuela, and the United States, according to Purdy.

Canada's previous prime minister, Justin Trudeau, famously welcomed refugees to his nation at the start of the first Trump administration. But attitudes have since shifted, according to Daniel Béland, director of the McGill Institute for the Study of Canada.

"What Justin Trudeau said in 2017 really backfired against him," Béland said. Pandemic-fueled inflation and a growing housing crisis as many refugees were coming to Canada "led to a backlash," he said.

So when Carney, a member of Trudeau's Liberal Party, campaigned to succeed him this spring, he tacked to the center on immigration. And when Carney's government introduced its first bill, the message was clear.

"A strong border is essential to our national security, to foster safe communities and support our economy," said Minister of Public Safety Gary Anandasangaree at a press conference.

The legislation would grant authorities new powers to search mail, curb the importation of chemicals used in fentanyl production, and share information about sex offenders with the US and other countries. Some of the measures aim to appeal to a domestic audience, according to Béland, while others seem like "a sequel" to Canada's efforts earlier this year to show the Trump administration it was focused on fentanyl smuggling and illegal immigration.

Asked at a press conference whether the bill was an attempt to "appease" the Trump administration, Anandasangaree said he expected it to "strengthen the relationship with the United States."

Human rights activists have expressed alarm at provisions that would make it harder to seek refuge in Canada. It would prevent those who have been in the country for more than a year to claim asylum, and it would close a loophole allowing those who illegally cross the border from the US to seek asylum if they remain undetected for 14 days. Authorities would also be empowered to cancel immigration permits "for matters of public health or national security."

"It's this massive expansion of state power that can be used for any purpose," said Syed Hussan, a spokesperson for Canada's Migrant Rights Network.

The Refugee Centre, a Montreal-based nonprofit serving new Canadians, is quick to feel the effects of immigration policy changes on either side of the border. Its clients are most commonly from Haiti and Venezuela at the moment, according to spokesperson Alina Murad, but it hasn't detected a surge in asylum-seekers relocating from the United States.

Murad says she understands that citizens of Canada and the US alike "are hurting and feeling the effects" of inflation and the housing crunch. But she believes people from elsewhere "are being used as scapegoats."

"It's not fair to blame refugees and immigrants for bad policies in other areas," she said. "These are people who are just trying to get to safety."

Ours: 3071 tokens